Q+A

LEADING MAN

Randeep Hooda dons the added mantle of director with the biopic, *Swatantrya Veer Savarkar*

Q. What was your biggest challenge with the Veer Savarkar biopic?
Once I started researching Savarkar, I became so involved, I ended up writing the script and directing it. The biggest challenge was the paucity of credible information on him. Savarkar's philosophy that the nation is above religion is relevant to our times. This biopic will help people understand why he was called 'Veer'. Another challenge was to look and talk like him.

Q. Do you prefer biopics over other genres?
Somehow they just come to me. I feel enriched after portraying a real person. I have done biopics like *Rang Rasiya* (on Raja Ravi Varma), *Main Aur Charles* (on Charles Sobhraj) and *Sarbjit* (on Sarabjit Singh). Now I play Savarkar, and it has turned out to be one of my favourite roles.

Q. Why did you opt for a Meitei wedding in Manipur at a troubled time?
Traditionally, weddings take place at the bride's home and I wanted to be a part of Lin's family and culture. Lin's brother later said that in spite of being a Jat, I was the best Meitei groom. Even though there was no internet in the state, the wedding photos went viral!

Q. When you are not acting, what do you do?
I love spending time with animals. I am also a keen wildlife photographer. Of late, a cat has adopted us, and my mare has had two babies and I also have a dog. So I have a lot of non-verbal communication with my animal family. Lin loves animals too...otherwise she would not be my wife!

–with Shashi Sunny



CHITRDEV